To mask or not to mask was becoming a rather sticky subject around the world. Since the beginning of March, our scientists, specifically Dr Guleria, were adamant that the contagion was spreading through aerosols and the best way to stop transmission would be to have face masks.

Taiwan was heavily relying on mask mandates. A country with a population of 23 million was manufacturing 13 million masks per day.[14] Similarly, Hong Kong too, one of the most densely populous cities in the world, was strictly enforcing mask mandates and seeing a great amount of success in controlling the pandemic. To understand how stringent the masking mandate was for them, a scientist advising the Hong Kong government commented in the media, 'Not wearing masks in Hong Kong is like not wearing pants.'[15]

However, larger nations were struggling to enforce these mandates. In February, Dr Anthony Fauci, the director of the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases in the US, almost condemned healthy people wearing masks. The US's Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) and its then director Robert Redfield echoed a similar tune. However, as more behavioural patterns of the virus came to be known, some high-ranking Americans began to advocate their strict usage. There was a popular story of the former deputy NSA to President Trump, Matthew 'Matt' Pottinger, doing the rounds at the time. He was on a call, while driving to the White House, with a doctor in China in the first week of March, trying to figure out all the things that had helped China contain the contagion. He made notes on the back of an envelope, while using the other hand to navigate traffic. The doctor on the line was giving out very useful information which included something about the prudence of an antiviral drug remdesivir. But then he specifically talked about masks and the fact that they were even more effective in combatting COVID-19 than influenza. He stressed, 'It's great to carry around your own hand sanitizer, but masks are going to win the day.' However, in the US, masks had become a political litmus test where many conservatives condemned mask mandates as infringements on liberty. So much was the resistance that even the president chose not to wear a mask, in private meetings or in public.[16]

The scientific advisory group in the UK too was advising against mask usage in the early days, leaving Prime Minister Johnson in an uncertain situation.[17]